

Chapter 23: After

Jenny kept telling herself “after” didn’t mean anything.

It was just a word.

A habit.

A way of speaking.

But the problem was...

Austin said it like it did.

Like it had structure.

Like it had intention.

And now, every hour that passed in the restaurant felt like it was moving toward something instead of just ending.

Jenny hated that feeling.

Because it meant she was waiting.

And she didn’t wait for people.

Not anymore.

By the time closing approached, Jenny had already cleaned the same counter twice.

Bao noticed immediately.

“You’re nervous,” he said.

“I’m tired.”

“You’re pacing mentally.”

“I’m not pacing anything.”

Bao leaned against the wall.

"He's still outside."

Jenny froze slightly.

"...What?"

Bao nodded toward the front.

"He didn't leave."

Jenny looked.

Through the glass.

Austin.

Standing outside the restaurant.

Not sitting.

Not waiting at a table.

Just... there.

Like he didn't belong inside anymore.

Like he was choosing the outside on purpose.

Jenny turned away too fast.

"Of course he is."

Bao smiled slightly.

"He said he was waiting for 'after.'"

Jenny sighed sharply.

"That's not helpful."

"You're going to go out there."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"I'm not."

Bao raised an eyebrow.

"You're already walking slower."

Jenny stopped.

"...I am not."

Bao just looked at her.

Jenny hated that silence more than words.

Because it confirmed everything.

When the last customer left, Madam Chen locked the door early.

The restaurant emptied into its final quiet.

Jenny stood behind the counter longer than necessary.

Cleaning nothing.

Doing everything.

Avoiding the moment she knew was waiting.

Bao passed by.

"You know," he said casually, "this is the part where you either run or don't."

Jenny didn't look at him.

"I'm not running."

Bao smirked.

"Sure."

Then he left her alone.

Jenny stood there for another full minute.

Then another.

Her reflection stared back at her faintly in the glass counter.

Tired.

Thin.

Still.

Someone who had survived a lot.

Someone who didn't usually hesitate.

So why now?

She exhaled slowly.

And walked out.

The night air hit her immediately.

Cold.

Quiet.

Too quiet.

And there he was.

Austin.

Exactly where Bao said.

He turned when he heard the door close.

No surprise.

Like he had been expecting her.

Jenny stopped a few steps away.

"You're really doing this," she said.

"Yes."

"Standing outside a restaurant waiting for me."

"I said I would see you after."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"That sounded less literal in my head."

A faint pause.

Then—

"I meant it literally."

Jenny sighed.

"You don't do anything halfway, do you?"

Austin shook his head slightly.

"No."

That answer should have been annoying.

It wasn't.

Jenny looked at him properly.

The streetlights made his expression softer than usual.

Less sharp.

More human.

"You could have just gone home," she said.

"I didn't want to."

A pause.

Then Jenny asked quietly,

"Why?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Not because he didn't know.

But because he was choosing the words carefully.

Then he said,

"Because if I left, I would go back to wondering."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"About what?"

"Whether this was real," he said.

A beat.

"And I don't want to wonder anymore."

Silence.

The wind moved slightly between them.

Jenny felt her hands tighten in her sleeves.

"You're making this sound bigger than it is again," she said quietly.

Austin stepped forward one small step.

Not closing distance completely.

Just enough that she had to look at him fully.

"Then tell me what it is," he said.

Jenny hesitated.

That was the problem again.

She didn't have a clean answer.

Not anymore.

Because "nothing" wasn't true.

And “something” was too vague to hide behind.

So she said honestly,

“I don’t know.”

Austin nodded once.

“That’s fine.”

Jenny blinked.

“...It is?”

“Yes.”

A pause.

Then softer—

“I don’t need certainty from you yet.”

That word.

Yet.

Jenny felt something in her chest tighten.

“You’re patient,” she said quietly.

“I’m not usually.”

“Then why now?”

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said simply,

“Because I don’t want to miss you by rushing.”

That landed too deeply.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

But this time...

Austin didn't let the silence fall apart.

He said quietly,

"I'm not asking you to decide anything tonight."

Jenny looked back up.

"...Then what are you asking?"

A pause.

Then—

"Just don't disappear."

That was it.

No demand.

No pressure.

Just that.

Jenny stared at him.

She should have said something clever.

Something defensive.

Something safe.

But instead...

She nodded.

Small.

Almost invisible.

"...Okay."

Austin exhaled slightly.

Like something inside him had loosened.

Not resolved.

Just... steadied.

Jenny immediately added,

"But don't make this weird."

A faint flicker of something like amusement crossed his face.

"I already failed that."

Jenny almost smiled.

Almost.

Then she turned slightly.

"So what now?" she asked.

Austin stepped back to give her space.

"Now," he said quietly, "we learn how this works."

Jenny shook her head.

"That sounds like another problem."

"It will be."

She sighed.

"...Great."

A pause.

Then Austin said,

"I'll walk you home."

Jenny looked at him.

"You're not my bodyguard."

"I know."

"I can walk myself."

"I know."

"Then why?"

A pause.

Then simply—

"Because I want to."

Jenny stared at him for a moment.

Then finally muttered,

"You're really annoying."

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

But he didn't move away.

And Jenny didn't tell him no.

So they walked.

Side by side.

Not close.

Not distant.

Just... there.

And for the first time...

"after" didn't feel like an ending at all.

It felt like the beginning of something neither of them fully understood yet.